



Northstar Analytics Data Classification and Handling Standard

Requirements for identifying protecting sharing retaining and disposing of information

Standard owner	Information Security	Version	1.0
Effective date	September 26 2026	Applies to	All Northstar information

1 Purpose and Scope

This standard establishes a consistent method for classifying and handling Northstar Analytics information according to sensitivity, legal and contractual duties, and the harm that unauthorized disclosure, alteration, loss, or unavailability could cause. It applies to information in any form, including databases, analytics models, dashboards, source code, documents, messages, recordings, printed material, credentials, and client-provided data.

All employees, contractors, temporary workers, vendors, and other authorized users must apply these requirements throughout the information lifecycle. When law, contract, client instruction, or another Northstar standard is more restrictive, the more protective requirement controls.

2 Classification Principles

- **Default protection.** Treat unmarked Northstar information as Internal until the owner assigns another classification.
- **Minimum necessary.** Collect, access, use, copy, and share only the information needed for an authorized business purpose.
- **Highest applicable level.** A file, dataset, message, or system inherits the highest classification of the information it contains.
- **Owner accountability.** The business or data owner assigns classification, approves access and sharing, and reviews protection and retention requirements.
- **Reclassification.** Classification may change when sensitivity, obligations, aggregation, or business use changes; declassification requires owner approval.

3 Classification Levels

Level	Definition	Examples
Public	Approved for unrestricted external release. Unauthorized change may still harm Northstar.	Published website content, approved press releases, public job postings.
Internal	Nonpublic routine business information whose disclosure would cause limited harm.	Internal procedures, ordinary project plans, general team communications.
Confidential	Sensitive information whose disclosure, alteration, or loss could materially harm a person, client, or Northstar.	Client data, employee records, contracts, nonpublic financials, source code, model artifacts.
Restricted	Highest-sensitivity information requiring tightly controlled access because compromise could cause severe harm or trigger legal duties.	Authentication secrets, private keys, government identifiers, payment data, regulated or specially restricted client datasets.

4 Marking and Inventory

Owners should label Confidential and Restricted information in document headers, filenames, repositories, metadata, dashboards, or system records when practical. Public information must be approved for release. Internal information may be marked when context is unclear. Systems that cannot display labels must record classification in an inventory, catalog, access rule, or associated procedure.

Removing or changing a label does not by itself change classification. Copies, exports, screenshots, backups, derived data, and analytic outputs must retain the source classification unless the owner documents that sensitive elements have been removed or transformed so reidentification is not reasonably likely.

5 Access and Use

- **Public.** May be accessed and shared without confidentiality restrictions after release approval; protect integrity and approved wording.
- **Internal.** Limit to Northstar personnel and authorized parties with a business need. External sharing requires owner or manager approval.
- **Confidential.** Grant role-based, least-privilege access to named or controlled groups. Owner approval and appropriate contractual safeguards are required for external sharing.
- **Restricted.** Limit to specifically authorized individuals, use strong authentication, log access where supported, and review permissions at least quarterly or as required by contract.

Users must not access information because it is technically available. Access must be connected to current duties and removed promptly when no longer needed. Segregation of duties, client restrictions, geographic limits, and export controls must be enforced where applicable.

6 Storage and Processing

Store and process Northstar information only in approved systems. Internal information may use standard approved business services. Confidential information requires approved managed storage, access controls, and encryption at rest where supported or required. Restricted information requires explicitly approved locations, encryption, strong access controls, logging, and any required client or regulatory safeguards.

Do not store Confidential or Restricted information in personal accounts, unapproved cloud services, local downloads, removable media, public repositories, or unmanaged devices. Production data may not be copied into development, testing, demonstration, or training environments unless the owner approves and appropriate masking, minimization, and security controls are applied.

7 Transmission Sharing and Collaboration

Verify recipients, permissions, classification, and business purpose before sending or sharing information. Use approved collaboration platforms and encrypted transmission for Confidential and Restricted information. Restricted information must not be sent through ordinary email or consumer messaging unless an approved encrypted method and owner authorization are used.

External sharing requires the minimum necessary data, an approved recipient, applicable confidentiality and data-protection terms, and a defined return or deletion requirement. Public links, open channels, anonymous access, and broadly shared folders are prohibited for Confidential or Restricted information. Printing should be avoided; when authorized, sensitive material must be secured from view and retrieved immediately.

8 Analytics Artificial Intelligence and Derived Data

Analytics, machine learning, and artificial intelligence activities must use approved tools and datasets. Do not enter Internal, Confidential, or Restricted information into public or unapproved AI services. Owners must evaluate whether aggregation, linkage, inference, model outputs, embeddings, logs, or prompts increase sensitivity. Derived information must be classified at the highest applicable level and reviewed before publication or external delivery.

9 Retention Backup and Disposal

Retain information only as long as required by the Records Retention Policy, client agreement, law, business need, audit, investigation, or legal hold. Approved backups inherit the source classification and must receive equivalent protection. Users must not delete, alter, or destroy information subject to a preservation notice.

When authorized retention ends, securely delete electronic information using approved methods and destroy paper so it cannot be reconstructed. Restricted information and storage media require verified destruction or sanitization. Owners must ensure vendors return or delete information and provide confirmation when required.

10 Third Parties and Cross Border Handling

Before a third party receives Confidential or Restricted information, the owner must confirm due diligence, approved contract terms, authorized purposes, security controls, incident-notification duties, subprocessors, retention and deletion terms, and geographic restrictions. Cross-border access, storage, or transfer requires applicable Privacy, Legal, Information Security, client, and International Remote Work reviews.

11 Loss Exposure and Incident Reporting

Immediately report suspected loss, misdelivery, unauthorized access, public exposure, incorrect permissions, unapproved processing, or inability to account for Confidential or Restricted information to Information Security. Preserve evidence and follow response instructions. Do not independently investigate, contact affected parties, or delete relevant material unless authorized under the Security Incident Reporting Procedure.

12 Roles and Responsibilities

Role	Responsibilities
All users	Apply labels and handling controls, verify recipients, protect information, complete training, and report suspected exposure immediately.
Data and business owners	Classify information, approve access and sharing, define retention, review controls, and authorize reclassification or disposal.
System owners	Implement access, encryption, logging, backup, retention, and deletion controls appropriate to hosted classifications.
Information Security Privacy and Legal	Maintain requirements, advise on safeguards and obligations, review exceptions and transfers, and coordinate incident response.

13 Exceptions Compliance and Related Documents

Exceptions require a documented business need, risk assessment, compensating controls, owner approval, Information Security approval, and an expiration or review date. Violations may result in access restriction, corrective action, contract remedies, legal action, or separation. Northstar prohibits retaliation for good-faith reporting of security, privacy, legal, or ethical concerns.

Related documents include the Information Security and Acceptable Use Policy; Security Incident Reporting Procedure; Access Control and Identity Management Procedure; Records Retention Policy; Company Equipment Lifecycle Policy and Procedures; Remote and Hybrid Work Policy; International Remote Work Policy; and applicable client data-handling instructions.